

Expected Journey 012 — The Three Gifts

PARTY LEVEL 4 · GUESTS LEVEL 3

BRACKEN HOLLOW

SEVEN PLAYERS · THREE HOURS



THE TRUTH

Marigold, the healer in the cottage past the edge, is one face of something much older. Every 27 years she gave the village a gift made from what the last trouble left behind, and asked that it be kept quiet. A month ago, on the Night of the Eye, all three came due.

Tonight: learn the three gifts, take them back, and seat them in the nook at the top of the hill.

THE THREE GIFTS

	BLACK	RED	WHITE
TROUBLE	The Dark Harvest 54 years ago. Famine, then starving wolves in the lanes.	The Blood Summer 27 years ago. A hobgoblin horde shut Kalaman in. Its foragers came for the grain.	The Pale Fever Last winter. Rain ran through the burial pit on the hill into the creek.
WHO ASKED	Gribb Brack, for his starving children.	Becklin, Boyd's knight.	Miren Vask, for his wife Sela.
GIFT	Black seed. Plant this.	Red banner. Fly this. A Brack grain sack soaked in hobgoblin blood.	White tooth. Wear this. A hobgoblin tusk curved like a crescent moon.
IT BOUGHT	Fields that never failed.	A last stand that held.	Sela got up.
WHERE NOW	Gribb's field corner, under the frostlace.	Over the gate.	Around Sela's neck.
THE TELL	The wolves always come out of one field. <i>The guests know.</i>	The fighting always starts at the gate. <i>Boyd knows.</i>	One woman never feels sick. <i>Nora and the cots know.</i>
OLD ECHO	A farmer kneels to plant.	A knight hands a folded cloth up to a sergeant on a ladder.	A man ties a cord on a woman in bed.
WHEN PULLED	One black wolf. Sky goes black. Howling on the hill.	The raiders' captain. Sky goes red. Horns on the hill.	Sela dies and rises. Echoes stop, the sickness lifts. Murmuring on the hill.

THE CLOCK

0:00	1 Down from the Hill	25
0:25	2 Three Gifts	30
0:55	3 Taking Them Back	30
1:25	4 The Hill and the Cottage	60
2:25	Closing	20
2:45	Slack	15

TONIGHT HAS TO LAND

- ☐ **Guests:** one fight, one clear job (carry), one thing only they know (the wolf field), one knack each (page 7).
- ☐ **The goal, said out loud:** three things, into the nook.
- ☐ **Roshi's send-off:** the shield wakes.
- ☐ **Kakashi's send-off:** the second mark, once.
- ☐ **Marigold** did this, and now she knows them.
- ☐ **The company splits:** four to Kalaman, three to Rookledust.

Late: Boyd names the places; narrate the pulls. **The hill starts by 1:30.** It may need the slack.

GOAL Guests in. Hill settled. Boyd opens the door to Becklin and Marigold. Rest.

READ ALOUD

The Stone lies where it fell, its head a pace from its shoulders, the three rings on its chest gone dull. Overhead the moons ease apart by a finger's width, and a pale wash settles over Bracken Hollow like the first hour of a gray morning. Beside you, Ked groans and opens his eyes. He is still here. So is everyone else. Down the path, two strangers are climbing toward you, and behind them comes an old sergeant, slower, looking at the fallen Stone as if he has waited a month to see it.

- BEATS**
- ☐ **The hill, settled.** Nobody was taken, for the first time in a month. Ked walks down. Corvin is home; his girl **Wren** watches from the doorway, glowing black. The taking is postponed.
 - ☐ **The guests.** Here a week; Boyd pulled them indoors under the red moon. Their letter is from **Barrowmere**, a village in Hinterlund, a week west, named for its old burial mounds. Mercenaries hold it. Let them introduce themselves.
 - ☐ **The goal, said plainly.** Three things hidden in the village go into the three recesses under the hilltop.
 - ☐ **Boyd goes quiet** at "three recesses." The Blood Summer: the village cut off, and his knight rousing farmers to a fight they should have lost. He wishes they could ask Marigold. She helped them then.
 - ☐ **"My knight was reassigned to Vogler."** If asked, the name: Becklin.
 - ☐ **Rest.** Keep it loose. The sky holds at white until the first gift is pulled.
- IF TIME** The wyrmling story: Ispin talked Becklin into a cavern, they lost, and Boyd hauled them out of a ravine. · Becklin's letter about the funeral. · The shield, which Boyd places only after her name is spoken.
- IF STUCK** Boyd keeps his promise from last session: he walks Kakashi to **Gribb Brack** for the frostlace. That is the seed.
- OUT** Questions about Marigold or the siege → Boyd walks them to the edge. Straight to searching → the gate echo catches them, with Boyd standing beside it.

- GOAL** The party knows there were three gifts, what they are, and where. Any order, any route.
- NEW TODAY** With the Stone felled, **older days show through**: an old echo at each gift, and three walkers at the edge. All new, even to Boyd.
- LAND THESE**
- ☐ **Marigold gave the banner.** Boyd's story · the gate echo · the red fighting always starts at the gate.
 - ☐ **There were three, 27 years apart.** 54, 27, last winter · the three walkers · three knots, three rings. Kakashi: 27 years is eighteen alignments.
 - ☐ **The seed is in Gribb's field.** The guests' wolf tell · the frostlace errand · follow the farmer · ask Gribb plainly.
 - ☐ **The tooth is on Sela.** Nora on the cots: "never so much as a cough" · follow the carpenter · Sela's tells.
 - ☐ **Marigold is something else.** All three walked out of her door · "keep it quiet" · nobody remembers her coming.

READ ALOUD — THE EDGE

The path climbs toward a tidy cottage and then, without any sign you can point to, stops letting you climb. As you reach that line, three figures step out of it together and walk down toward the village. A farmer in his prime, in clothes two generations old, a small pouch in his hand. A young knight in Solamnic plate, smoke behind her, a folded cloth under her arm. A carpenter in a winter coat, snow on his shoulders, something closed in his fist. They pass through you as if you were the ghosts, and at the foot of the path they part three ways.

- IF STUCK** Boyd: "Three things, three places, seven of you." Old Gribb can supply any history. Detect Magic within 30 feet shows a gift as a knot.
- OUT** One team per gift → cut between them. Together → three short scenes in a row.

GOAL Each gift bites when it is pulled, as a taste of what waits on the hill. The hard choice at the Vask house.

- RULES**
- **A pull drags the sky to that color and holds it there.** No echoes outside White.
 - **One guardian at the spot: 10 hit points per character there.** After two rounds it breaks for the hill.
 - **On the hill:** that color's horde gathers and its ring lights on the Stone.
 - **All three pulled is the full eclipse.** They may also take one gift up at a time.

SEED☐ PULLED

Where. Gribb's field corner, where the frostlace grows. Old Gribb at the fence.

Gribb. Shows the corner if asked plainly. Wants to hear he did right by his children.

The pull. The frostlace and the seed come up in the same handful. Kakashi's errand is done.

Black wolf. AC 13, HP 10 each. Bite +4, 7 (2d4+2).

After. Sky black. The field stays bare. Howling on the hill.

BANNER☐ PULLED

Where. Over the gate. Boyd holds the ladder.

The pull. The red comes off on Boyd's hands, and it is the wrong color for dye. Under it, a faded stamp: a Brack grain sack.

Becklin never knew.

Raiders' captain. AC 15, HP 10 each. Sword +4, 8 (1d8+4). One tusk curved like a moon.

After. Sky red. Horns on the hill.

TOOTH☐ PULLED

Where. On a cord at Sela's neck. Boyd knows it on sight: the captain's tusk.

The pull. She dies and she rises, even if she gave it freely. That is Marigold's cruelty.

Sela, risen. AC 8, one hit. Slam +3, 4 (1d6+1).

After. Echoes stop. The sickness lifts. A murmur of many voices on the hill.

SELA Warm, quick, color in her cheeks, tending the cots because she never catches it. She died last winter and does not know. Miren half knows and has not let himself check.

HER TELLS Her breath does not show in the cold. Cold hand. No pulse (Medicine). Roshi's Divine Sense reads undead. Kakashi knows an animated body.

STALL LEVER **Ten minutes of circling and she finds out:** she overhears, she notices her own breath, she sees Miren's face. If nobody will say it, Corvin does, for Wren. She asks one small thing of the party, then takes the cord off herself.

GUESTS Give them the wolf or the captain.

OUT Gifts in hand → the villagers gather behind Boyd and everyone goes to the foot of the hill.

IF THEY...

Pull early, or pull the tooth first	The echoes stop. Boyd, Gribb, Nora and the tells carry the rest.
Take one gift up the hill at a time	Allowed, with one ring lit, one horde, and one Slam a round. Warn them it means three climbs.
Try to destroy a gift	Cut or burned, it is whole in the hand again. It can only go back.
Refuse the tooth, or hide Sela	The stall lever. She chooses.
Go after Corvin, or ask about the glows	A frightened father who drops his dagger; Wren is in the doorway. The glows are the spell's tally, and breaking it wipes them.
Turn Undead on Sela	It works. She backs away for the minute. Use it for Miren.
Fly the gifts up (Jasper's boots)	Let it work. The waves reach the air, the light follows the gifts, and he saves at minus three.
Hit the Stone and name no ring	Split the damage across the lit rings. Only Compelled Duel holds it. Faerie Fire: advantage on rings.
Carry with Mage Hand or a familiar	It can carry, and the light can take it. Only a living hand can seat a gift.
Clear the crowd with a spell	Round one: normal damage; Turn Undead clears the risen. Later: skip the next fray roll of 1 to 3.
Want to hunt Marigold afterward	Her trail runs toward the other villages. Carry it forward.

READ ALOUD — THE STONE STANDS

The three moons slide into one eye. On the hill, stone grinds on stone: the head rolls back to the shoulders and the Stone stands up whole, and its rings light one after another: white, then red, then black. It steps off the crown of the hill, and behind it is the dark mouth of the hole it stood on. The old path winds up toward it, and the slope is moving: black wolves, raiders in rusted mail, and the pale dead of last winter. They are already coming down. Behind you, Boyd is shouting the village into a line.

TO WIN

Seat all three gifts in the nook at the top of the hill. Everything else is optional help.

THREE SWITCHES PER COLOR

WHITE

RED

BLACK

Gift seated → its horde stops and its fray line is skipped

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☐

Ring dark (45 HP each) → no concussive wave in that color

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☐

Talisman broken or gift seated → no light wave in that color

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☐
☐

FOOT

Round one starts here.



DOTS 0 TO 2

60 feet. Black reaches.



DOTS 2 TO 4

60 feet. Black, red.



DOT 4 UP

30 feet to the hole. All three.

EACH ROUND. 1. Players, in seat order. 2. The Stone attacks. Plus two legendary Slams, each at the end of a player's turn.

THE STONE. It stays by the hole. Its rings are its hit points. One attack on its turn. **Fist:** reach 15 feet, +8, 10 (2d6+3). **Rock:** anyone on the hill, +8, 7 (2d6).

THE SLAM (LEGENDARY, 2 A ROUND). Tick the next box: white, red, black. A quiet or lost Slam is still spent. Two waves:

CONCUSSIVE WAVE. 20 feet from the Stone. **Strength save,** DC 15, or 7 (2d6) and pushed 15 feet back down the path. They keep what they hold.

LIGHT WAVE. Whoever holds that color's gift, within that color's reach of the hole: **Charisma save,** DC 15, or taken.

TAKEN. Everything they hold drops. They take their next turn in the cottage, then come back to where they stood.

STEP IN. Anyone within 5 feet may take the light and roll instead. If they fail, they are taken and the carrier keeps the gift. A dropped gift draws its light onto the nearest player or villager in reach.

THE PATH. 150 feet, normal movement, a dot every 30. Dashing every round, a carrier seats in round three.

SEAT. An action at the hole, one gift per action, by a living hand.

CLIMBING AND FLYING. Off the path: an action and Athletics DC 13 for 30 feet straight up. Flying is allowed, and the waves reach the air. Off the path, reach is 30, 60 and 90 feet from the hole.

RINGS ON ITS CHEST. AC 17, 45 hit points each. The attacker names a ring. No ring named: split the damage evenly across the rings still lit. At 0 a ring goes dark and a piece of the Stone breaks away.

ALL THREE RINGS DARK. The Stone falls. The light waves go on alone, one a round.

THE HORDE, ROUND ONE: THE PRESS. One of the horde is on each player: AC 13, 11 HP, +4, 7. Drop it, or leave it standing and it attacks once as they move off or end their turn. End of the round: Boyd's line hits the slope, takes whatever is left, and the two cancel out.

ROUND TWO ON: THE FRAY. Roll a d6 each round. 1 to 3 land only while that color's horde is still coming. Running long: stop rolling.

1 Wolves. They bite the lowest player on the path: +4, 7, and prone on a hit.

2 Raiders. A volley at the highest player on the path: +4, 7.

3 The risen. A face the village knows blocks the path ahead of the lead player. AC 8, 1 HP, or 15 feet to go around.

4 The line holds. Describe it and move on.

5 A gap opens. The lowest player on the path moves 30 feet for free.

6 Village bows. The Stone's attack this round has disadvantage.

SLAMS USED

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TEMPO

Faster: spend both Slams. Slower: hold one. Boyd or Ked can carry on the turn of whoever asks, saving at +0.

TAKEN

OUT

Third gift seated → the Stone comes apart, the moons part, and the edge opens on a true autumn evening.

READ ALOUD — TAKEN

The light closes over you, and then it is a kitchen. A fire, a pot, bundles of herbs drying from the beams, and along one wall a long row of small things: a child's shoe, a pipe, a wedding band. An old woman looks up from the pot as if you had knocked. She wears a pendant and two earrings, each cut with a mark you have seen on the Stone's chest, and one of them is glowing.

- THE TURN** Each taken player waits here until their own next turn, takes it, and is then sent back to **where they stood**, with no save. Two or three can be here at once.
- THEY CAN**
- **Break the glowing talisman.** AC 13, one hit. It is the color that took them, and only the lit one can be harmed. That gift can never be taken again. **All three broken destroys her**, and the hill goes on.
 - **Look.** One more detail of the row on the wall. Leave what she wants them for unsaid.
 - **Talk.** She plays the kind old healer, pleased to have company, and gives nothing away.
 - **Swing at her.** It lands like a blow on a sack of straw. She tuts. The talismans are what hold her together.
- MARIGOLD** An ordinary old woman who has aged alongside Gribb. This one is a puppet, with something far away holding the strings. She never attacks. The light was built to bring her one frightened villager at a time, so armed strangers in her kitchen are a problem: she puts them back on the hill and lets the Stone deal with them.
- HER EXIT** The puppet comes apart when the third talisman breaks or when the spell does, whichever comes first. As it goes she says, in essence: that is enough, she got more out of this than she expected, and they are interesting. She will be keeping an eye on them. If the spell breaks with nobody in the kitchen, the party finds her in the doorway, already coming apart. The hearth is cold and has been for weeks. The fire they saw was never there.

ROSHI · THE SHIELD WAKES

☐ LANDED

What it is. The shield answers her memories of Ispin. Each one she tells can become an ability.

Trigger. The first time a light wave falls on her, or on anyone within 5 feet of her, the story she told at his funeral comes to mind: the bear den, the honey, the bears waking, and her stepping in front of him. Then ask what she does.

If she stands in the light, for herself or for someone else, it breaks on the shield and nobody is taken by that wave. Boyd sees it. **The bear den wakes** until the spell breaks.

The Bear Den. Advantage on Strength checks and saves, and she cannot be moved. After she hits with a melee attack, a bonus action bashes: any size, pushed 15 feet, prone, +1d8.

On the Stone. A bash knocks it flat, and it loses its next Slam.

If she is taken first. Marigold looks at the shield and says someone is in there.

After. Slumbering: +1, the boulder-or-tree disguise, A Life Worth Living (drop to 1 instead of 0, once a day), Shield Bash, two leaves, one memory.

KAKASHI · THE SECOND MARK

☐ LANDED

Wakes. The first time someone is taken in front of him, a second mark turns in his eye. It fades once he has cast the copy, or when the eclipse ends.

The light is Banishment (4th level, Charisma save).

Copy. Reaction when he sees a light wave. **Arcana DC 19, with advantage** under the eclipse. Fail: 1d4 psychic (reduced for tonight). He may try every round.

On a success. One cast within the minute, no slot. Two points of exhaustion. Sealed until wizard level 7.

His copy follows her rule: the target is gone for one round. On the Stone, that is a round with no attack and no Slams, and it lands in Marigold's garden, outside her window.

Defense. If he carries, Perception DC 14 gives advantage on the save.

If he asks to cast it again. Allowed under the eclipse, with no new check. Each cast adds two more exhaustion: four, then six, and six is death. Tell him that before he chooses. If he dies, see the Closing.

ARATOS

First time an enemy damages him in a rage: let it go, or hold it. **Wisdom DC 14 (+2), advantage if protecting someone.** Stepping in for a carrier counts. Success: the axe goes cold, trial mark ☐. Failure: berserk on the nearest creature that is not one of the horde, new save at the end of each turn. A hit from the horde counts. The Horn is spent.

- ☐ **The cottage.** The edge is open. Marigold's goodbye, if it has not been said. Then a cold hearth, a heap of clothes in the chair, and the long row of small things, about thirty of them.
- ☐ **The village.** Ordinary fields, no crop this year, Kalamán a day away. Sela is laid to rest. Mayariel can lead it. Miren needs someone.
- ☐ **Boyd and Becklin.** The party tells him: Vogler fell, two cuts across the back at the docks, the Vingaard. He may hand Roshí Becklin's letter about the funeral.
- ☐ **The raven.** Wyhan, to Kakashi and Jasper: Wayreth is closed to candidates while the war lasts, their standing is provisional, the Test will wait. Fizban is in her shop every day asking for Kakashi's wand and Roshí's shield.
- ☐ **Only if Kakashi died of the third cast.** He lies under the last of the eclipse as the moons part. The three gods of magic speak in turn, then together. He breathes, with five points of exhaustion, and is carried to Kalamán.

READ ALOUD — THE THREE MOONS (ONLY IF HE DIED)

White: *You have a lifetime of magic to learn, young Watcher. Do not throw it away so eagerly. We have spent much to return it.*

Red: *Even from her prison, Takhís's shadow lengthens. The balance strains under it. We cannot hold it alone.*

Black: *The last tower that could right it. My mother would leave it beneath ruin. We would not.*

All three: *Find it. Raise it. Keep it.*

- ☐ **The roads.** Kakashi, Roshí and the guests west to Kalamán with the letter. Aratos, Mayariel and Jasper east to Tatína Rookledust.

SPOTLIGHT (ONE MOMENT EACH)

ROSHI	Divine Sense at the cots finds Sela. Becklin's banner. The shield wakes. <i>Exit: Fizban asks for the shield.</i>	☐
KAKASHI	Frostlace over the seed. Counts the alignments. The second mark. <i>Exit: the raven.</i>	☐
MAYARIEL	Bless on the carriers. Lays Sela to rest. Narrate her magic for her.	☐
JASPER	Private notices: Corvin watching the Vask door, the sack stamp, the breath that does not show. The flying gamble. The raven is for him too.	☐
ARATOS	Ked walks because of his promise. Stepping in for a carrier. The rage save.	☐
THE GUESTS	They know the wolf field. A first fight each. Each carries a gift up the hill. They leave with the letter.	☐ ☐

CAST

WHO	VOICE	WANTS	KNOWS, DOES
Sgt. Boyd	Short sentences, dry. Early sixties.	The taking to stop. News of his knight.	Hung the banner, dug the pit on the hill, knows the captain's tusk. Has not heard that Vogler fell.
Old Gribb Brack	Mid-eighties. Slow, exact.	To be told he did right.	Planted the seed. Knows the village's history. "Nobody remembers Marigold coming."
Sela Vask	Warm, quick. Cold hands.	Her neighbors well.	Dead since winter. Learning it ends her.
Miren Vask	Carpenter. Guards his wife.	One more ordinary day.	Went up the path last winter. Half knows.
Corvin and Wren	Forties, broad, calm on top. His girl is quiet and watches him.	Wren safe, whatever it costs someone else.	Tells Sela if nobody else will. Wren glows black until the spell breaks.
Ked	Shaken. Loyal to Aratos.	To repay it.	Will carry a gift if asked.
Nora	On a cot, tired, grateful.	To be up again.	"Sela sat with us all. Never a cough."
Marigold	Kind, unhurried, amused.	To watch. Then to be elsewhere.	In the cottage, as a puppet. Never attacks. Three talismans hold her together.

REFERENCE — ONLY IF YOU NEED IT

THE GUESTS TONIGHT (THEY PICK TWO OF FIVE SHEETS)

SHEET	THEIR KNACK, AND WHERE IT PAYS OFF	ON THE HILL
Fighter	Know Your Enemy. Studying the fallen Stone: its rings are its life, 45 each.	Holds ground (Strength save +5). Steps in.
Ranger	Primeval Awareness. Undead near, yes. Fey near, yes. Tracks the wolves.	Best shot at the rings (+7).
Sorcerer	Telepathic Speech. Miren, unheard by Sela. It reaches the cottage.	Best carrier (Charisma save +5).
Artificer	One elixir: swiftness suits a carrier. Detect Magic shows each gift as a knot.	Faerie Fire on the rings. Heals.
Bard	History: the Blood Summer, theirs to tell. Medicine: Sela has no pulse.	Best carrier (+5). Inspiration on a save.

WHERE WE LEFT OFF

The party took Ked up the hill, dimmed the Stone's three rings, and Aratos beheaded it while berserk; Roshi dropped him at 2 HP. Corvin struck Ked down and ran. Under the hilltop, Kakashi and Jasper found three recesses: three components, somewhere in the village.

ALREADY SAID AT THE TABLE

- **The cycle.** One day. White is the longest, about half. Then red, then black, then an eclipse of about an hour.
- **White.** People feel a little sick. Echoes of villagers live an ordinary day. Some have watched their own.
- **Red and black.** Red: a battle in the streets, which killed most of the militia. Black: wolves, and the only time the farms give food.
- **The glows and the count.** Everyone white, fewer red, five or six black. The taken come from the black. Of about 200, about 40 are gone.
- **Marigold.** Healer and something of a mystic, cottage just outside, travels between villages, away the night it closed.
- **Gribb Brack.** The farmer a few houses down who would know about frostlace. Boyd offered to take them under the white moon.
- **The rings.** Striking one stripped something from the Stone. Kakashi saw a lattice over the village with three knots.

NEW CANON MADE TONIGHT

- **The Blood Summer.** 27 years ago a hobgoblin horde besieged Kalamán. The walls held, and the city had nothing to spare.
- **Becklin.** Mid-twenties then, on her first command. Boyd, ten years older, was her sergeant.
- **The hill.** The horde's dead were burned and buried in a pit on its crown, under the stones. Rain ran through that grave into the creek.
- **The Bracks.** The first farm, and the village carries the family's name. Gribb was about thirty in the Dark Harvest.
- **Ispin's shield.** It answers Roshi's memories of Ispin. Slumbering now, with the bear den as its first memory.
- **Kakashi's eye.** The second mark showed once. Banishment is sealed in it until wizard level 7. He earns the mark properly in the Fizban thread.

MARIGOLD, LONG TERM (NONE OF THIS IS SAID TONIGHT)

- An arch-hag who collects souls the way a night hag does, for something unnamed. The cottage woman is one of many proxies in other villages.
- Possibly Hiddukel above her. Her anathema is undecided.

SECRETS & CLUES

- ☐ The three gifts go into the recesses. That is what breaks it.
- ☐ Frostlace grows in one place here: over the seed.
- ☐ Boyd's knight in the Blood Summer was Becklin.
- ☐ Sela Vask has no pulse.
- ☐ She came down from the healer's cottage with colors to fly.
- ☐ The tooth is the raiders' captain's tusk, from the pit on the hill.
- ☐ The banner is a Brack grain sack, and the red is hobgoblin blood.
- ☐ Kalamán sent no help because it was under siege itself.
- ☐ Three walkers came from Marigold's door, each carrying something.
- ☐ Nobody remembers Marigold coming to the village.
- ☐ Three troubles, 27 years apart, each with a name.
- ☐ The taken went to her kitchen. She kept something of each.

CARRY FORWARD TO EXPECTED JOURNEY 013

The company is split: Kakashi and Roshi to Kalamán and Fizban's errand; Aratos, Mayariel and Jasper to Tatina Rookledust. The guests' village still needs help. **Record:** who was taken, how the tooth came off, what Boyd was told, the shield and eye moments, and Aratos's trial marks. **To write:** the shield's full stat block. Swap the Horn of Valhalla to the newer version.

[illegible]

NEXT SESSION MUST RESPECT	